

The Dialectology of Evidential Strategies in Georgian

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The Georgian language has long stood as a byword amongst linguists for many typological features: its unusually liberal syllable structure, its system of case-marking featuring shifts of case both across tenses and conjugation classes, and its baroque, polysynthetic verb matrix. Less well-known however are the tense-aspect oppositions that set Georgian, and Kartvelian more generally, apart from ‘Standard Average European’ languages. The Caucasus, like the Balkans and unlike the languages of northwest Europe, is a hotbed of evidentiality under various guises, and Georgian is no exception to this rule. In the following pages, I will examine not just how evidentiality functions as a grammatical category in literary Georgian, but also look at new strategies not found in standard written texts. In many cases, these dialectal constructions show that evidentiality is evolving new forms and functions not typical of the written language.

§1 Phylogenetic and Historical Prolegomena

Georgian belongs to the Kartvelian language family, long situated in the western portion of the southern Caucasus range at the pivot of Eurasia. Along with its sister languages Megrelian, Laz and Svan, its long tenure in this region – it has been spoken here since at least the second millennium BCE in the Middle Bronze Age – means that it has been in contact with many of the best understood and best attested language families, including Indo-European languages like Hittite, Greek, Armenian and Persian, Semitic languages like Akkadian, Aramaic and Arabic, and Altaic languages like Turkish and Azerbaijani, as well as autochthonous language families like Abkhaz-Adyghean and Nakh-Daghestanian.

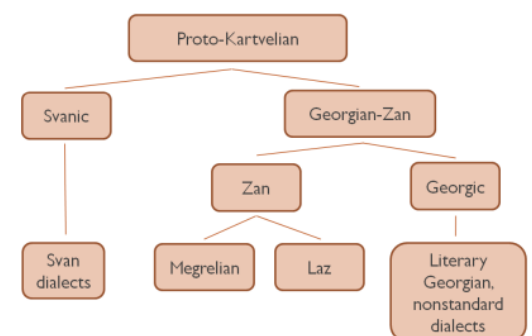
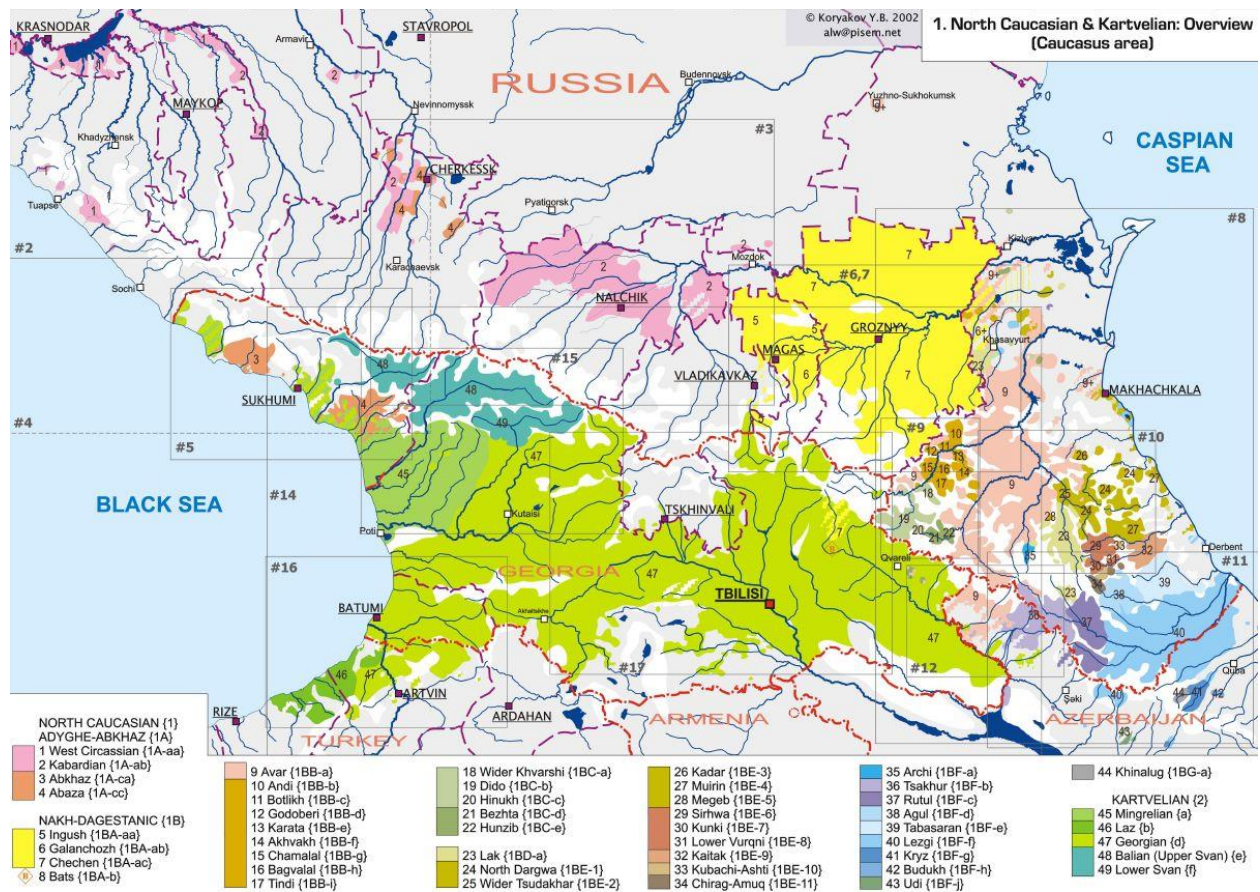


Table 1. Phylogenetic tree of the Kartvelian languages



Map 1. Languages of the Caucasus (Koryakov 2002)

§2 Evidentiality in the Georgian Literary Language

2.1 Evidentiality in formal oppositions

Though such languages share many features in common, one particularly widespread feature is evidentiality, the marking of the source of information in a clause. This is typically fused with other features such as tense, aspect, or mood, but may be flagged by other properties of the clause such as case. In Georgian for example one finds contrasts such as that in (1):

- (1) a. C'uxel da-v-l-i-e sam-i dasalev-i
last.night PVB-1-drink-AOR-AOR.1/2 three-NOM drink-NOM
'I drank three drinks last night.'

- b. C'uxel da-m-i-l-ev-i-a sam-i dasalev-i
 last.night PVB-1SG-PRV-drink-TH-PF-3SG three-NOM drink-NOM
 magram ar m-a-xs-ov-s
 but not 1SG-PRV-remember-TH-3SG
 'I (apparently) drank three drinks last night, but I don't remember.'

The opposition seen between the aorist narrative past tense in (1a) and the perfect evidential past tense in (1b) is typical example. Aorist tense verbs are used to make authoritative statements about the narrative flow of events, while perfect evidential tense verbs lessen the narrator's explicit commitment to the veracity of the statement. The construction in (1a) would thus imply that one drank three drinks and knows this from first-hand knowledge, while the statement in (1b) might be used when the narrator deduces what happened from indirect evidence, e.g. seeing three bottles on the table, or three missing bottles in the refrigerator, without being able to claim knowledge as a witness.

However, it also has formal features that set it apart from evidential found in many other languages. The first is that it involves Georgian's complicated system of case-assignment in which the case assigned to subjects, direct objects and indirect objects shifts from one tense to the next. Consider the following examples in (2) to (4):

(2) Present (Future):

Vano c'ign-s (da)-c'er-s
 Vano.NOM book-DAT (PVB)-read-3SG
 'Vano is / will be writing the book.'

(3) Aorist:

Vano-m c'ign-i da-c'er-a
 Vano-NARR book-NOM PVB-write-3SG
 'Vano wrote the book.'

(4) Perfect-evidential:

Vano-s c'ign-i da-u-c'er-i-a
 Vano-DAT book-NOM PVB-PRV-write-PF-3SG
 'Vano has (apparently) written the book.'

	<i>Transitive</i>	<i>'Medial' Intr.</i>	<i>Stative Intr.</i>	<i>Dative-Affective</i>
<i>PRESENT-FUTURE</i>	SUBJ: NOM IOBJ: DAT DOBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM
<i>AORIST</i>	SUBJ: NARR IOBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM	SUBJ: NARR	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM
<i>PERFECT- EVIDENTIAL</i>	SUBJ: DAT IOBJ: PP DOBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM

Table 2. Georgian case assignment across different tense series and conjugations.

In the present and future series form in (2)¹, the subject of the sentence is flagged by NOMINATIVE case and the direct object by DATIVE case, while in the aorist forms in (3), the subject is now marked by NARRATIVE case and the direct object by NOMINATIVE case. The perfect evidential in turn marks subjects with DATIVE case and direct objects with NOMINATIVE case. Thus the evidential forms of verbs assign case distinct from both present-future series and aorist series forms of verbs.

To make things more complicated, the system described above in (2) to (4) applies only to transitive verbs, as Georgian has so-called 'Split-S' alignment for case. Intransitive predicates show splits based on Aktionsart and telicity (Holisky 1981), in which agentive atelic intransitive verbs mark case in the same way as subjects of transitive verbs, while stative intransitives and dative affective verbs show no shift of case assignment at all across the tense aspect series: stative intransitives always take NOMINATIVE case for subjects, while affective verbs always take DATIVE case, as in Table 2. Thus the case distinction between evidential tense forms and nonevidential tense forms is simply neutralized for these verb classes.

What's true of case is also true of agreement, in a slightly different sense. While verbs agree for both subject and object in all three series, the present-future and aorist series of verb tenses show suffixal agreement for the subject and prefixal agreement for

¹ The present and future tense forms of verbs in Georgian have the same case assignment system, but are distinguished by the presence of a lexical preverb in the future with present tense suffixes; present tense forms simply lack the preverb.

indirect objects. In the perfect-evidential series, this system is roughly inverted: the same slots that mark subject in the first two series now marks object agreement, and the erstwhile slot on the verb for indirect objects (noted as PRV for ‘preradical vowel’ in (4)) now betokens marking for the notional subject. Though the origins and functioning of this complicated system are beyond the scope of this paper (see Harris 2020), the salient fact for our purposes is that evidential marking is not so much *fused* to tense/aspect as it is *suffused* throughout an entire construction type, by being flagged through both case and different kinds of agreement morphology. To put it differently, because there is a many-to-many mapping of case form and agreement type to grammatical function, evidentiality is only sometimes flagged, in some constructions with certain verb types.

2.2 Semantic-pragmatic functions of evidential forms in Literary Georgian

The above formal mechanisms are found in a number of different semantic-pragmatic contexts, as noted extensively by the most extensive study of evidentiality in Georgian, Boeder (2012). Unwitnessed events can be deduced from both visual and auditory contexts:

(5) Unwitnessed action: visual

Int’erviu	ar	še-dg-a...	tovl-i	mo-sul-a
interview	not	PVB-take.place-AOR.3SG	snow-NOM	PVB-go.PF-3SG

‘The interview did not take place... [apparently] it snowed.’ (*Georgian National Corpus, hereafter GNC*)

(6) Unwitnessed action: auditory

P’at’ara	bič’-i	ga-mo-sul-a,	ga-u-g-i-a,
Little	boy-NOM	PVB-VENT-go.PF-3SG	PVB-PRV-understand-PF-3SG

rom	rağac	xmaur-i	q’opil-a
that	something	loud-NOM	be.PF-3SG

‘The little boy came out, he heard there was [apparently] something loud.’ (*GNC*)

In the forms in (5) and (6), the speaker is deducing informational status from subsequent evidence, such as the appearance of snow on the ground or a boy’s alertness to noise. These kinds of inference involve straightforwardly direct perceptual information, but sometimes inferences come from a general understanding of the world and its people. In (7), the speaker simply deduces personality types from life experience:

- (7) eg ise=c q'vela-m i-c-is... šen-is-tan-eb-i
 this.NOM thus=too all-NARR PRV-know-3SG 2SG-GEN-such-PL-NOM
 cot'a *m-i-nax-av-s*
 litte.NOM 1SG-PRV-see.PF-TH-3SG
 'Everyone knows this... I have [apparently] seen a few of your type.' (GNC)

In other cases, the evidential form takes on a mirative sense of surprise, delight or discomfort from previously unknown information as in (8):

- (8) Msgavs-i čem-i p'at'ara er-is ist'oria=ši
 similar-NOM 1SGPOSS-NOM little.GEN nation-GEN history=in
 ar *mo-mxdar-a!*
 not *PVB-happen.PF-3SG*
 'Something similar has [apparently] never happened in the history of my small country!' (GNC)

And in other cases, the evidential takes on a similar twist when reporting ironically on newly discovered facts about a given situation, as in (9), where the speaker muses on the likelihood of someone claiming to speak sixteen languages fluently:

- (9) Tağlit-i namdvil-i poliglot'-i *q'opil-a:* tekvsmeť'-i
 scammer-NOM real-NOM polyglot-NOM *be.PF-3SG* sixteen-NOM
 ena *s-codn-i-a!*
 language.NOM 3SG-know.PF-PF-3SG
 'The scammer was [apparently] a real polyglot: he [apparently] knew sixteen languages!' (GNC)

Evidentials can also indicate that reported information is merely hearsay or opinion, as for example in (10), where uses to invoke a certain rugby player's worldwide reputation:

- (10) Gemriel-ad k'i ragb-ob-s, r-is gamo=c
 delicious-ADV indeed play.rugby-TH-3SG which-GEN because.of=REL
 mtel ragbet=ši *ga-varđn-i-a* saxel-i
 whole.DAT rugby.world=in *PVB-fall.PF-PF-3SG* name-NOM
 'He plays rugby deliciously [*sic*], which is why his name has spread through the whole rugby world.' (GNC)

Closely related to this usage for hearsay is the usage of evidential to relay traditional understandings or narratives about history, legend, or lore:

- (11) Mat tav-i Zagros-is mt-eb-is=tvis
 3pl.DAT REFL-NOM Zagros-GEN mountain-PL-GEN=for
še-u-par-eb-i-a-t da lok'alur-ad *da-saxl-eb-ul-an*
PVB-PRV-cover.up-TH-PF-3SG=PL and local-ADV *PVB-settle-TH-PF-3SG*
 '[The Fereidan Georgians of Iran] took refuge in the Zagros Mountains
 and settled locally.' (GNC)

The example in (11) refers to the Georgians of Fereidan, Iran, who descend from the Georgians deported by Shah Abbas I in 1614-1617, many centuries before any current speaker was born.

As a result of such usages, the evidential-perfect sometimes has knock-on pragmatic effects for the usage of tense-aspect series as a whole. That is, the choice to use a perfect-evidential can sometimes lead to positive pragmatic implicatures in *other* tenses such as the aorist or imperfect not specifically found in the perfect-evidential itself. As an example, choice of the aorist can sometimes lead to the implication that the speaker has directly experienced the experience:

(12) Perfect-evidential:

Nik'o Pirosman-s es surat-i *da-u-xat'-i-a*
 Niko Pirosmani-DAT this.NOM painting-NOM *PVB-PRV-paint-PF-3SG*
 'Niko Pirosmani painted this picture [I recognize his style]'

(13) Aorist:

Nik'o Pirosman-ma es surat-i *da-xat'-a*
 Niko Pirosman-NARR this.NOM painting-NOM *PVB-paint-AOR3SG*
 'Niko Pirosmani painted this picture [I saw him do it]'

We can even show in fact that these are pragmatic implicatures, and not entailments of the truth-conditional meaning of the aorist, because they can be defeated by direct contradiction:

- (14) Nik'o Pirosman-ma es surat-i *da-xat'-a*;
 Niko Pirosmani-NARR this.NOM painting-NOM *PVB-paint-AOR3SG*
 ase amb-ob-s am c'ign=ši
 thus say-TH-3SG this.OBL book=in
 'Niko Pirosmani painted this picture; it says so in this book.'

Note that these facts conform to a semantic model in which the evidential-perfect creates pragmatic presuppositions, using the present tense to anchor evidence to the utterance time (Izvorzki 1994, Iatridou & Izvorski 1997).

Another way in which the perfect evidential interacts with other notionally nonevidential tenses is under negation. Because negated events necessarily cannot be witnessed, the perfect-evidential has become the pragmatically unmarked to negate events in the past tense. So for example if one says as in (15) that one has not bought a book, it bears no more exceptional implicatures than that it did not happen:

- (15) Perfect-evidential:
 Is c'ign-i ar *m-i-q'id-i-a*
 this.NOM book-NOM not *1SG-PRV-buy-PF-3SG*
 'I didn't buy this book.'

Negation of the aorist in this context could however have additional implications. It could be taken, as in (16), to imply for example that the speaker did not buy the book because the speaker did not want to do so:

- (16) Aorist:
 Is c'ign-i ar *v-i-q'id-e*
 this.NOM book-NOM not *1-PRV-buy-AOR.1/2*
 'I didn't buy this book [because I didn't want to].'

The Georgian evidential-perfect tense can also be used with interrogative constructions, but when doing so, it undergoes an egophoric shift of perspective from the speaker's information source to that of the addressee:

- (17) Šen es k'ac-i an ak an sxvagan
 2sg this.NOM man-NOM or here or else
 sadme *g-i-nax-av-s?*
 somewhere *2-PRV-see.PF-TH-3SG*
 'Did you see this man either here or somewhere else?' (GNC)

This is significant, because in languages which are sensitive to constraints on egophoricity, the egophoric marker (denoting information accessible to the speaker) and the alterphoric marker (denoting information accessible to another person) are typically incompatible with evidential markers. As De Lancey (2018) notes that in a system that distinguishes evidential marking and egophoricity ‘direct statements are subject to verification, and thus must be specified for evidentiality, while personal statements do not allow evidential marking’ with the consequence that an evidential marker cannot be used for first person because a speaker cannot speak objectively about himself or herself. That is, egophoric shifts of the kind seen in (17) are impossible with the same morphosyntactic machinery. Thus evidentiality in Georgian, where both first and second person make use of the same basic construction, is unlike the system found in Lhasa Tibetan or Newar where such constraints do exist.

2.3 Quotative clitics and evidential verb forms

In addition to the synthetic evidential-perfect verb forms discussed above, Georgian also possesses a secondary set of quotative clitics that mark the predicate (though not always a verb) as reported speech. In these constructions, the quoted speech is preserved exactly in the form heard by the speaker, but with the addition of clitics indicating whether the grammatical subject of the reported clauses is the same or different from that of the immediate speaker. In (18) for example, the speaker is theoretically quoting himself, and so adds the quotative clitic =*metki* (historically from *me vtkvi* ‘I said’):

- | | | |
|------------------------------|---------------|--------------------|
| (18) Tkven-i | mdgomareoba | čven-sa=ze |
| 2PL.POSS-NOM | situation.NOM | 1PL.POSS-DAT=on |
| iol-i=a= <u>metki</u> | rom | g-i-txr-a, |
| simple-NOM=be.3SG=REPT.1 | that | 2-PRV-tell.AOR-3SG |
| ar g-e-c’q’in-os | | |
| not 2-PRV-bother-OPT.3SG | | |
- ‘If I told you that your situation is better than ours, you would not mind’ (GNC)

A second-person quotative clitic =*tko* is typically used when giving commands in which the addressee is to repeat an exact phrase or construction:

- (19) G-a-gvian-d-eb-a=**tko**, u-txar-i
 2-PRV-late-INGR-TH-3SG=**REPT.2** PRV-tell.IMP-IMP.2
 'Tell him "you are late".' (GNC)

By far the most common quotative clitic is =*o*, which is used when the speaker wants to repeat what some third party not in the present conversation has said, as in (20). This can be used even when that speech-act nonparticipant doesn't actually overtly say a specific comment, but (the speaker presumes) was merely thinking it, as in (21):

- (20) Davit-ma m-i-txr-a, rom Giorgi-m
 David-NARR 1SG-PRV-tell.AOR-AOR.3SG that Giorg-NARR
 q'velaper-i ga-i-g-o=**o**
 everything-NOM PVB-PRV-understand-AOR.3SG=**REPT.3**
 'David told me that Giorgi understood everything.'

- (21) Rağac-is tkma u-nd-od-a, da q'oq'man-ob-d-a –
 something-GEN say.NOM PRV-want-IMP-3SG and hesitate-TH-IMP-3SG
 vaitu vitareba ga-v-a-rtul-o=**o**
 lest development.NOM PVB-1-PRV-complicate-OPT.1/2=**REPT.3**
 '[He] wanted to say something, but hesitated – why complicate the
 situation?' (GNC)

An important feature of these quotative clitics is that they are systemically distinct from the evidential-perfect verb forms discussed in previous sections. We can show this because they in fact have overlapping syntactic distributions, and so can be used concurrently with each other. In the form in (22), the speaker has previously stated to someone else that they have not washed their hands, and so used the evidential-perfect as the unmarked way to indicate that something did not occur in the past. But because they are quoting themselves in the current situation, they additionally use the quotative clitic =*metki*:

- (22) Am c'uta-s ča-mo-ved-i, xel-i=c
 this.OBL second-DAT PVB-VENT-come.AOR-AOR.1/2 hand-NOM=too
 ar da-m-i-ban-i-a=**metki**
 not PVB-1SG-PRV-wash-PF-3SG=**REPT.1**
 'I came this second, I did not even wash my hands, I said.'

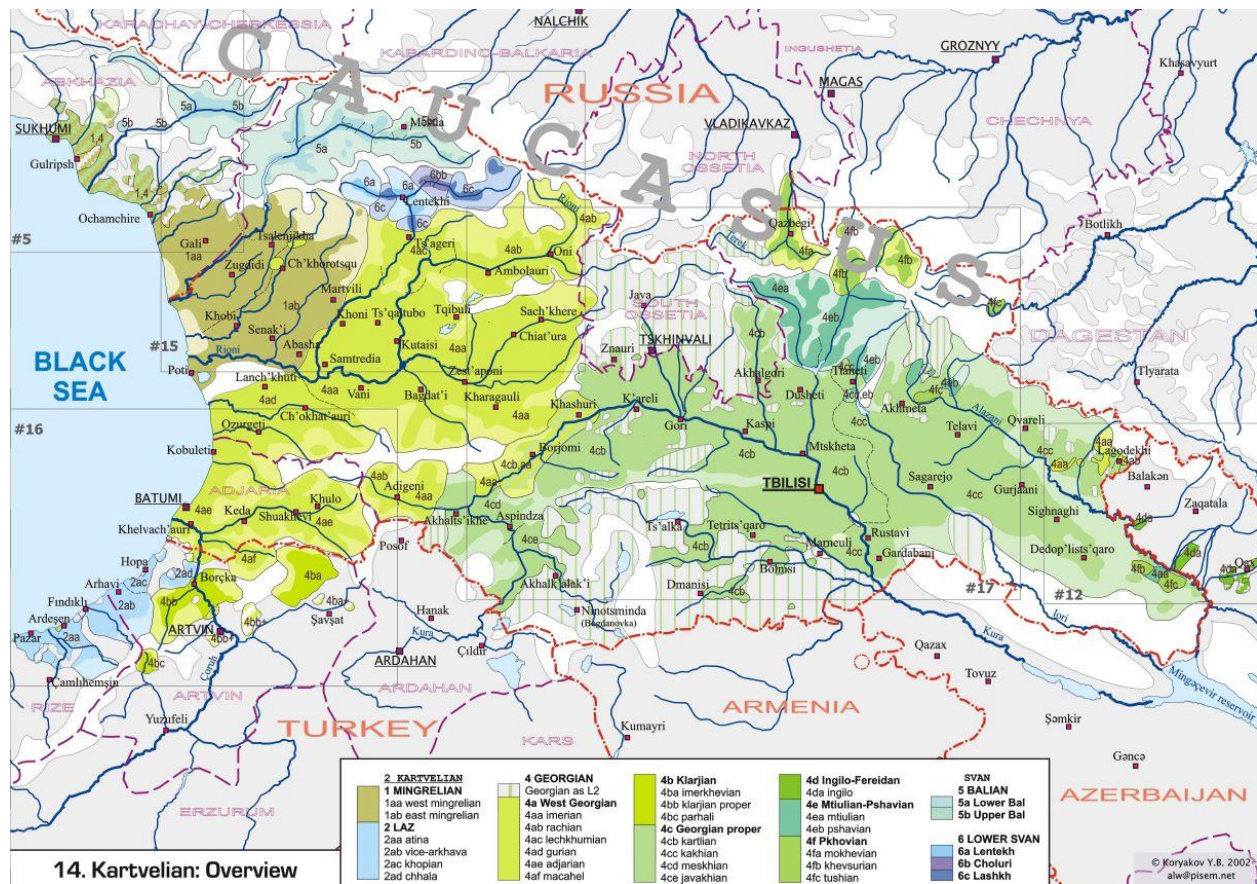
Another illustration of their separate distribution comes from quotatives attached to imperatives. In Georgian, imperatives are formally morphologically identical to the aorist past tense, and because the evidential-perfect is a fusion of tense and evidentiality, it cannot be used in the imperative. Quotative clitics can however:

- (23) Is angeloz-i c'uxel-i=c mo-m-e-vlin-a
 That angel-NOM last.night-NOM=too PVB-1SG-PRV-come.AOR-AOR.3SG
 da m-i-txr-a "Eg u-tu-o-d
 and 1SG-PRV-tell.AOR-AOR.3SG this.NOM PRIV-doubt-PRIV-ADV
 mo-a-xdin-e=o!"
 PVB-PRV-accomplish-IMP=REPT.3
 'That angel visited me again last night and told me: "You will surely
 accomplish it!"'

§3 **The dialectology of evidential strategies**

Though literary Georgian sometimes presents a hegemonic picture of linguistic uniformity, this is emphatically not the case amongst the spoken dialects of Georgia and neighboring countries. Georgian dialects may be, very roughly, divided into a few macroregions that reflect the topography of the region (see Map 2): 'Colchidian' dialects of western Georgia and adjacent regions of Turkey, including Imeretian, Gurian, Ajarian, Rachan, Imerkhebian and Klarjetian; 'Iberian' dialects of the central and eastern lowlands of Georgia and Azerbaijan, including Kartlian, Meskhetian, Kakhetian and Ingilo-Fereidanian²; and the conservative Mountain dialects of Mtiuletian, Mokhebian, Pshavian, Tushetian, and Khevsurian. There is in addition much language-mixing and contact between these varieties, with many shared lexical and grammatical isoglosses between and within regions.

² The Fereidan dialect is today spoken in the Isfahan Province of Iran, genetically an off-shoot of the eastern Ingilo dialect region, though now much mixed with borrowings from Persian not found in other Georgian dialects.



Map 2. Dialects of Georgian in the south Caucasus. (Korkyakov 2002)

In most cases, Georgian dialects pattern after the literary language in terms of how evidential perfect constructions are formed and used. In some cases however we see innovative forms found nowhere else. A first example comes from Ingilo dialect, spoken in northwestern Azerbaijan. In this dialect, a perfective form of the verb 'be' lacking its finite inflection, =*q'opil*, has become grammaticalized as a marker of evidential uncertainty, even in contexts where they would be impossible in the literary language:

(24) Present tense:

Ese:-n	bewr	muš-ov-en= <i>q'opil</i>
This-NOM.PL	much	work-TH-PRES.3PL=EVID
'They work a lot (so it's said)' (GDC)		

(25) Imperfect tense:

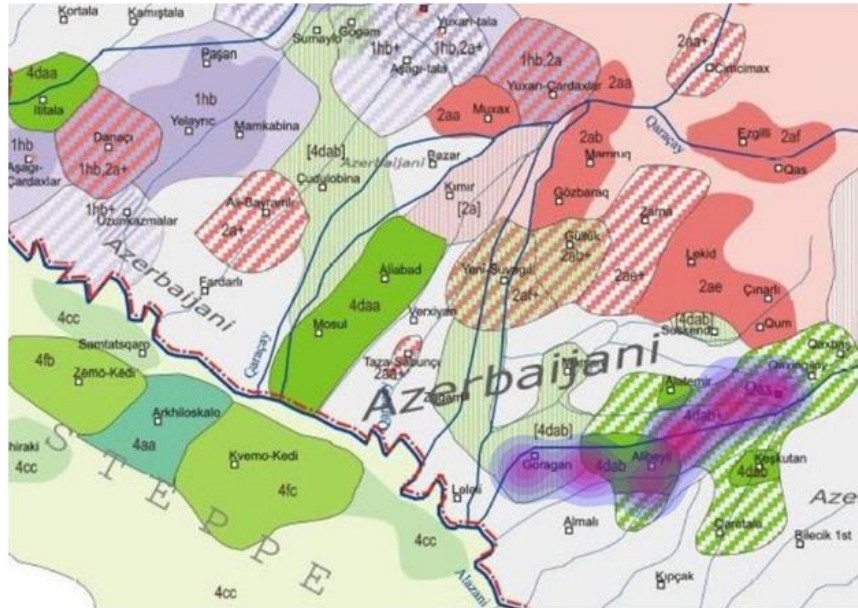
k'evr-it	k'alu-eb-s	lec'-av-d-nen=q'opil
threshing.board-INST	threshing.floor-PL-DAT	thresh-TH-IMPF-3PL=EVID
'They were (apparently) threshing (things) with a threshing board on the threshing floor.' (GDC)		

Note that unlike the regular literary evidential perfective, this evidential clitic can be used even in present or imperfective contexts where the action has not come to full completion. Another feature of this clitic is that, unlike the evidential perfect which shifts subject agreement to dative and object agreement to nominative case, this clitic does not impose a different case-array than the underlying tense construction onto which it is attached. That is, imperfective verbs standardly assign dative case to direct and indirect objects, not nominative case, and that is what we see in (25). Compare this to the neighboring varieties of Azerbaijani, whose evidential suffix *-mİş* can likewise be used to indicate imperfective states or actions, as in (26):

(26)	Uşaq	vaxt-ı	çox	kitab	oxu-muş
	child	time-3SG.POSS	much	book	read-EVID
	'Apparently, (he/she) used to read a lot of books as a child.'				

Another dialectal strategy used to indicate evidentiality can be found in the Tush dialect of Georgian spoken high in the mountains on the European side of the watershed³. Standard Georgian possesses an approximative suffix *-(i)ode* which attaches exclusively to numerals to produce a number with a vague cardinality: *sam-iode* 'about three', *as-iode* 'approximately one hundred'.

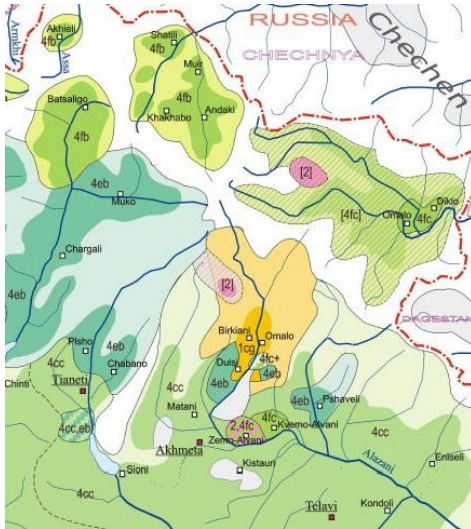
³ This is not to be confused with the unrelated Nakh language Tsova-Tush, a.k.a. Batsbi, a.k.a. Tush, which is now mainly spoken in the town of Zemo Alvani but which was once spoken in Tusheti.



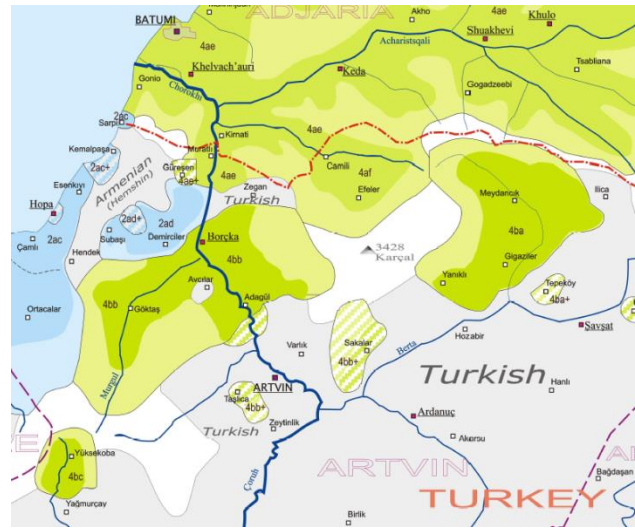
Map 3. Heat-map illustrating the distribution of the =q'opil evidential clitic in northwestern Azerbaijan. The clitic is mostly found in the Qax district along a specific tributary of the Alazani (Qanix) River. (Korkyakov 2002)

In Tush dialect of Georgian however this suffix =ot/=od has acquired a wider distribution, and can be attached to regular nouns with the meaning 'a little bit' and also sometimes induces sentential evidential readings:

- (27) p'ur-i=ot g-ši-an
bread-NOM=EVID 2-be.hungry-3PL
'You're hungry for loaves of bread [I can tell based on how you look/behave]'
(Jorbenadze 1989: 437)
- (28) tumc cot'a i-q'-o p'ur-i=oda
although little PRV-be-AOR.3SG bread-NOM=EVID
ar š-č'am-s
not PVB-eat-3SG
'Although there was little bread, so he [apparently] isn't eating' (GNC)



Map 4. Khevsureti, Pshavi and Tusheti, including communities speaking Khevsur ('4fb'), Pshav ('4eb') and Tush dialects of Georgian ('4fc') (Korkyakov 2002)



Map 5. Imerkhebian dialect speakers of Georgian in the Republic of Turkey (Korkyakov 2002)

This evidential is interesting in a number of ways. Firstly, unlike other evidential strategies in the standard language, this clitic does not exclusively attach to the verbal predicate, and indeed preferentially applies to noun phrases. This clearly results from its *degrammaticalization* as a nominal suffix, which is in itself typologically rare, as clitics usually originate as free words and then become progressively fused to their nominal or verbal hosts, not the other way around⁴. Secondly, in the literature on evidentiality, most of the proposed grammaticalization pathways that lead to evidential forms involve verbal predicates that become bleached of their original meaning as verbs of perception, speech or cognition and eventually take on more fully grammatical functions. This Tush clitic =ot/=od however shows that nominal affixes with the right original semantics may indeed evolve to take on evidential properties that apply to whole clauses. The Tush form is also typologically part of a broader pattern across many Eurasian languages in which a diminutive or comparative particle, adverb or construction comes to imply epistemic uncertainty. Consider for example Japanese in (29a), Spanish (29b) and colloquial English (29c):

- (29) a. Chotto muzukashii
 little difficult
 'It's a little difficult' (often meaning: 'It seems difficult')

⁴ Though note the case of English possessive <'s>, which has clear origins as a nominal affix and is now in colloquial English a clitic that takes whole phrases as its scope.

- b. Había como veinte persona-s
 exist.3sg like twenty person-pl
 'There were around twenty people'
- c. 'My mother is, like, a total space cadet.'
 (attributed to Frank Zappa's daughter, Moon Unit)

In such examples, the attenuating effect of a diminutive or a comparative particle serves to weaken the speaker's commitment to a claim, and in doing so highlight its uncertainty.

The Ingilo and Tush forms interest us in part because they represent entirely newly grammaticalized affixes not found in the literary language. Other dialects however have innovated evidential contrasts for specific lexical items that do not apply for the dialect as a whole. So for example in Pshav dialect, which like Tush is an eastern mountain dialect, the lexical verb for *mosvla* 'come' (regular perfective: *mosula* 'has apparently come') has developed an *imperfective* past evidential *modenila* 'was apparently coming'):

- (30) ga-i-kc-a garai=d a-zǵvav-eb-ul
 PVB-PRV-jump.up-AOR.3SG outside=and PVB-flood-TH-PART
 c'q'al mo-den-il-a
 water PVB-flow/come-PF-3SG
 'He ran outside and flood waters were apparently coming...' (GDC)

Further to the west in the dialects of Racha (spoken in west central Georgia) and Imereti (spoken in the western Colchidian plains) in contrast, an evidential present tense form *monavala* 'is apparently coming' has been innovated (as in 31):

- (31) Kvemo-Svanet=ši simid-i=c mo-na-val-a⁵
 Lower.Svaneti=to corn-NOM=too PVB-PF-come.AOR-3SG
 'Even corn is apparently coming to Lower Svaneti' (GDC)

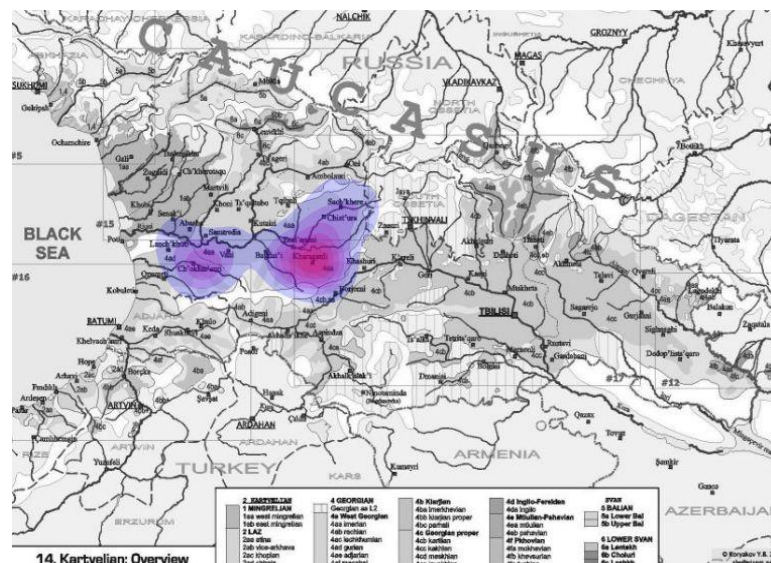
⁵ It is noteworthy that Megrelian likewise forms one of its evidential series with the cognate perfective prefix *no-*, e.g. *no-č'ar-ap-u-ap-en* 'he apparently makes him write it'. This may indicate another avenue of language contact.

A different kind of lexical innovation found in some dialects concerns new clausal particles that modify the semantic reading of the clausal predicate. For example, in Racha dialect in (32) and Imerkhebian dialect (spoken in far northeastern Turkey adjacent to Georgia) in (33), one finds numerous forms like *tu*, *ture*, *sture*, *stumte*, *megem* all meaning ‘apparently’:

(32) Sture mi-e-čv-i-a irem-i
 apparently PVB-PRV-get.used.to-AOR-AOR.3SG deer-NOM
 ‘The deer apparently got used to it.’ (GDC)

(33) Megem tlat c’ev-an da dzinw-an
 Apparently entirely lie.down-PL and sleep-3PL
 ‘Apparently they are all lying down and sleeping.’ (GDC)

In some cases these particles are native to Georgian, while in others they originate as loans from neighboring languages; e.g. *megem* comes from Persian *magar ham* ‘perhaps, by chance’, the same source as standard Georgian *magram* ‘but’⁶. Irrespective of their origin, these particles all indicate that the speaker was not a direct witness to a certain



Map 6. Heat map showing the dialectal distribution of the confirmative evidential particles *ke* and *kve* in Imeretian and Rachan dialects of Georgian. It follows the drainage basin of the Rioni River from its source almost to the Black Sea.

⁶ Variants of this same Persian source form *magar* ‘perhaps’ or *magar ham* ‘also perhaps’ appear in more than two dozen languages on all sides of Iran, including Armenian *magar*, *magam*, Azerbaijani *məğər*, Lezgi *meger*, Ottoman Turkish *meğər*, Punjabi *magar*, Rutul *megem*, Talysh *maqəm*, Urdu *magar* all meaning something like ‘perhaps’, ‘apparently’, ‘but’, ‘yet’, or other similar attenuating adverbs and conjunctions.

event or state. In contradistinction to this, some dialects have innovated particles, *ke*, *kve*, and *ko* that indicate the speakers were witnesses or have direct knowledge of an event. In Imeretian (33) and Rachan (34) dialects of Georgia's west-central alluvial plains and mountains (shown in Map 6), the particles *ke* or *kve* show speakers' commitment to particular claims:

(34) Ke g-i-txar-i, mara ar de-i-je-r-e
 EVID 2-PRV-tell.AOR-AOR1/2 but not PVB-PRV-believe-AOR1/2
 'I did indeed tell you, but you didn't believe it.' (Jorbenadze 1989: 482)

(35) sabdzel-i a-v-a-šen-e da mere
 silo.NOM PVB-1-PRV-build-AOR1/2 and then
 kve da-v-a-mgv-r-i-e
 EVID PVB-1-PRV-finish-AOR-AOR1/2
 'I built the silo and then I finished it.' (Jorbenadze 1989: 406)

In some cases, these can even be used in negated contexts where the particle confirms that the speaker did not experience a certain event, in which case they can be procliticized to the negative particle *ar* 'not':

(36) K=ar m-e-t'ek-a dzağl-i pex-eb=ši
 EVID=not 1SG-PRV-fight-AOR.3SG dog-NOM leg-PL=to
 'The dog didn't fight me round about the feet [I know, I was there].'
 (Jorbenadze 1989: 453)

(37) [A:] 'Rava ar-i, bič'-o, sakme-i=o?'
 what.kind.NOM be-3SG boy-VOC affair-NOM=QUOT
 [B:] 'ğom-i ke i-xarš-eb-a=o.'
 porridge-NOM EVID PRV-boil-TH-3SG=QUOT
 [A:] "What's going on man?" [B:] "The porridge is [indeed] boiling."
 (GDC)

In (37), we also see an example from Upper Imeretian dialect where the confirmative particle can be used to indicate what the speaker sees for himself in a currently ongoing act, and considers obvious. Thus unlike the literary standard, this particle too can indicate evidential information in imperfective contexts.

This particle *ke/ko* is transparently cognate with inherited *kve*; *ko* is a loan from Georgian's sister language Megrelian, where it is a confirmatory particle 'yes, indeed'. This not only reflects contact with the immediately adjacent Megrelian communities of Samegrelo, but also the specific hydrography of the Colchidian plains: the usage of these confirmative particles runs more or less consistently along the entire route of the Rioni River basin from its source in Racha almost to its effluence near Poti along the Black Sea.

§4 Generalizations

Lexical innovations such as new paradigmatic forms or evidential particles in these dialects are just as important as the grammaticalization of new affixes in Ingilo and Tush dialects because they reveal how speakers perceive a semantic-pragmatic paradigmatic gap which they are beginning to fill with different kinds of strategies. This has broad consequences for the use of evidential strategies as a whole.

The first generalization concerns different strategies that speakers are adopting with respect to tense. As noted above, the evidential-perfect is fused with tense features, and consequently in the literary language there is no direct, overt way to refer to evidential status in tenses other than the evidential-perfect. This is clearly not true in the nonstandard colloquial dialects of Georgian:

Generalization 1: *Speakers are adopting witnessed/nonwitnessed evidentials when not in the completed past.*

- (a) in **Ingilo** dialect, the grammaticalization of the finite verb =*q'opil*
- (b) in **Tush** dialect, the extension of the approximative suffix =*ot/=od* to mark sentential evidentiality on noun phrases
- (c) in **Pshav** mountain dialects and in western dialects of **Imereti** and **Racha**, the innovation of new nonwitnessed past imperfect paradigm forms of **verbs of motion**
- (d) in **Imerkhevian** and **Ajarian** dialects, free particles like *megem* may mark nonwitnessed contexts
- (e) in **Imeretian** and **Rachan** dialects, a confirmative particle *ke / kve* has evolved evidential uses for witnessed contexts

A second generalization comes from the context in which these dialectal innovations occur. Throughout its documented history, Georgian speakers have always been in contact with neighboring majority and minority languages, in many cases borrowing from their lexical items, patterns of phonology and grammatical constructions. And in the Caucasus, Georgian is surrounded on all sides by languages that possess a grammatical category of evidentiality, both in the autochthonous languages like Megrelian, Chechen, Tsova-Tush, Avar, etc and in the larger non-autochthonous languages like Turkish and Azerbaijani:

Generalization 2: *in many cases, we can point to probable language contact with languages possessing an evidential category as a possible source or influence*

- (a) **Ingilo** contact with **Azerbaijani** -*mIş*
- (b) **Imerkhevian/Ajarian** contact with **Turkish** -*mIş*
- (c) **Imeretian/Rachan** contact with **Megrelian** *kol/ke/kve*
- (d) **Tush** contact with Nakh languages like **Chechen**, **Ingush** and **Tsova-Tush** (aka Batsbi), which all have several nonpast nonwitnessed tenses

These points of similarity contain all the hallmarks of language change due to contact (Gast and van der Auwera 2012; Mithun 2025): (a) they contain structural innovation of a pattern that was not present in the language prior to contact, based on comparison with historical texts and the literary language; (b) replica grammaticalization where a language develops a new grammatical category by following the same path from lexical to grammatical meaning found in a "model" language; and (c) calquing or loan translation in which a construction is replicated using native morphemes but follows the exact structural or semantic logic of the donor language. In the case of contact with Turkic languages, we can even say that it is not merely the existence of shared evidential categories, but the same kind of opposition: what Johanson (1996; 2003) has called 'indirective' evidentiality, which mark the speaker's 'conscious reception' of the information at issue: 'evidentially unmarked forms may suggest that the source of information is direct experience', as we saw with in the case of Georgian negation. This cannot be an accident, especially given the

predominantly resultative meaning which the perfective forms conveyed in Old Georgian (Fähnrich 1994; Boeder 2012).

A final set of generalizations about these dialectal trends reflect not just contact but specific patterns and networks of social organization seen in the dialect geography:

Generalization 3: in some cases, we can point to dialectal features of evidential mirroring the local hydrography.

- (a) the **Ingilo** use of *=q'opil* follows an eastern tributary of the Alazani river basin
- (b) the **Rachan** and **Imeretian** use of *ke/kvel/ko* follows the Rioni river for almost its whole course

This last generalization is important because it reflects not a generalized external contact between people over large regions like the Caucasus, but specific microenvironments of contact between different communities of Georgians, and provides more evidence of different levels of language contact.

§5 Conclusions

This paper has surveyed a number of features of the Georgian system of evidentiality: the manner in which it is fused with tense-aspect oppositions, its interaction with case and agreement, the different kinds of pragmatic contexts in which it can be used, as well as its distinctiveness from the separate system of quotative clitics. These features of the literary language are all present to varying extents in the nonstandard colloquial dialects. Yet these nonstandard dialects show clearly how the system of evidentiality is evolving and changing in accordance with the different needs of its speakers: into new tense-aspect forms, and in different semantic-pragmatic domains of use, as well as responding to the larger extralinguistic context of external languages and in the way in which speakers interact with the landscape.

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